First Period and It's a Teenage Thang

by Kevin M. Derrig & Regie Gibson

half way through first period
dust accumulated on the sweaty palm of my
raised hand
must be a centimeter thick by now
as the chicken-legged teacher goes around the
room
defacing students' homework from last night
with red pen graffiti
that focuses more on missed commas than the
content of the sentences
he finally decides to acknowledge me
"Mr. Derrig, why do I have a feeling that this is
another one of your dumb
comments. You constantly waste my time. Why
don't you just drop out or something?"

4NG Fanatics

why don't I just drop out
why don't I just drop out!

INTRODUCTION

School should be a positive experience of learning, growing and becoming the person you are meant to be. Unfortunately, not all teachers possess the qualities of a nurturing" charismatic adult. And when students come in contact with these dream-stifling, spirit-crushing teachers, the impact they have can affect the way students feel about themselves for the rest of their lives.

First Period by Kevin M. Derring

and it was at that moment that all statistics
began to make sense to me
statistics of children whose mouths water more
for the many taste of
society corner slanged penicillins
than the cardboard textures of diplomas
with pipes more important to fill
than class requirements
statistics of classes cut

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to avoid battlefields full of aggravated shrapnel
from teachers with exploding tempers
teachers with magnifying glasses at the end
pointers
who feed off the brightness of surrounding
students
to singe holes in the esteems of those who need
just a little more help
than
others
I wanted to turn my shot-down hand into a fist
I wanted to hit him 'til he was incapable of
speaking anymore
but I didn't want to become another number in
overflowing manila folders
of children arrested in school
and we wonder why a gun seems to fit perfectly
in the hands of this generation's adolescents
ladies and gentlemen
I'm writing this poem to highlight that which has
been stuck like gum

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underneath wobbly desks
free from parental eyes
only to mess the hand of those who have to sit
there
I'm writing this poem to speak for all the rows of
children before me
who remained voiceless in the cracks of school
and its soundproof textbooks
I'm writing this poem for all the children who
have not yet been named
the ones that will one day have to fill these rows
I've been struggling in
only to enter classrooms where they'll be shot
down for what they feel
ladies and gentlemen
the future of America is being crushed between
the molars
of power-hungry tyrants who think class rooms
are boot camps
and if we have any teachers in the audience
I urge you to understand that the hand you grab

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the chalk with

the hand you grab those red pens with

the voices you speak with

are oversized chisels

and you must proceed to teach with caution

for what you say and what you do is written in

stone

and if you chisel too hard these minds can crack

"So what don't you understand now, Mr. Derrig?"

I just wanted to know if I could go to the bathroom

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin M. Derrig
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution: Slam, Hip Hop & the Poetry of a New Generation
ISBN: 978-1402202469
Publisher: Sourcebooks, Incorporated
Date (Month/Year): March 2005

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Qualifier

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TRANSITION

Let's face it . . . It's hard to be a teenager. You have the expectations of teachers at school and your parents at home – all looming over you – beating you down. What's a teenager to do?

According to Regie Gibson . . . "My mother is a very devout Jehovah's Witness, and has been for most of my life. My father, at one time, was a Chicago police officer. Neither one of them would allow me or my brother Ron to go out. So my brother and I would sneak out of the home when mama went to sleep and pops went to work." This is a recollection of what it meant to be young, defiant and feeling your oats at sixteen and is for every teenager who has rebelled against their parents by sneekin out. It's a Teenage Thang by Regie Gibson.

bass slides in on all fours
rabid with feral look in eyes
bodies twist
into
blasphemous
angle of
rebellion/defiance

something smellin
like
jail time
cuts across air
like hand fulls of zirconia
scratchin shit

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out of a plexiglass sky

over in corner
cue balls psychotic smack
breaks up tribe of stripes and solids
on field of green

black eight sinks
thru smoky haze of aw shits
damns as ten spots reluctantly
ruffle they ways
out pissed off pockets

d.j. priest
sittin reverently in the pulpit
jacks sounds in alternatin patterns
of thirty three and thirds

spinnin gospel
of our faith
as congregations hands

reach heavenward
exposin our palm to angles

as we hope to catch a
hallowed high five
from a god whose
pissed cuz shes gotta work
the night shift

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tonight

we be young
virile sweatin passions
ya gotta experience to understand

we don't give a damn
bout tympanic
cartilaginous erosion
of inner ears
weakened by 1200 to many
hot grindin weekends
of buttbumpinwoofinandtweetin

we don't give a damn
bout ass kickin
waitin on us when we get
home way past curfew

(ok a little)

but tonight we only care bout
ass kickin bass and drum
can give

ass kickin bass and drum
can heal

tonight we live for strobelights
kissin vision
bringin new sight

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for floors moanin with
weight of young
flippant attitudes

glasses mumblin
speech of stolen
kisses

sky exploding with funk
of flirtin smiles

we live for bodega crew
comin up from barrio
bringin supple
brown morenas con
hips like congas
gon-boppin
6/8 rhythm
from front door to dance floor

got you tryin to speak in language
you ain't ever tongued before
uh mira maimi uh pasie agee poo on
momentato po fayva
(or something like that)

big red manzana lips
partin ever so slightly
revealin thin sliver of pink tongue
rollin like scarlet smoke off roof of latina mouths

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we live for sisters
blue blacks honey browns
heavenly ebonies getting down
on legs shaped like mamas soulfood
with a whole lotta attitude

calves
carved
outta hams and hocks

with backsides big round sweet and tender
as grandmamas homemade biscuits
(have mercy)

they hair icked
slicked
tricked
or picked out
into
asymmetricalisoscelesrhomboidparallelograms

and a few other forms
defying geometric
classification

tonight

we be young virile
sweaty with passion
you gotta experience to understand

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tonight

be our night to hold somebodies body
to feel they eye lashes brush up against
face on slow jam

feel thin wispy fingers
of they breath invade
sensitive conch shell ear
like well trained guerillas

to hold them close firm heavin nubile
against the mask of teenage knowin
and adolescent pretence.

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